South Africa's large fuel market relies on substantial imports

21.0bn L

Estimated demand, 2025

8.9bn petrol and 12.1bn diesel

5.8bn L

Domestic production assumption

National planning baseline

16.7bn L

Gross import requirement

Broadly matches recorded imports

A substantial demand base

Road transport is the largest use. Mining, agriculture, manufacturing and power also contribute.

Demand has eased from 21.9bn litres in 2023 to an estimated 21.0bn in 2025.

Durban connects imports to inland customers

Durban customs recorded 13.16bn litres of imports in 2025. The Durban–Lesedi route provides access to inland demand, subject to customer and logistics access.

South Africa has an established import market serving a large national fuel requirement.

Department national sales; SARS 2025 trade; analytical workbook v02. 2025 demand is estimated; 5.8bn L production is a planning assumption. Gross import need includes exports and assumes no stock change.

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Changes in demand, domestic supply and import routes could reduce flows through Durban

Driver	What changes for fuel demand and Durban flows
Sector activity	Mining, manufacturing and agriculture follow different growth paths, changing equipment and freight demand.
Eskom recovery	More reliable electricity reduces peaking and backup diesel at utilities, mines, factories and farms.
Road-to-rail and efficiency	Rail recovery and vehicle efficiency can reduce the fuel required to move goods. Rail growth alone does not prove road displacement.
Domestic production	Higher refinery output or restarts could displace imports. Lower output would increase import dependence.
Competing gateways	Matola provides an alternative route for inland customers. Delivered cost, reliability and access determine the volumes it can win.

A large national import market does not automatically translate into growth for Vopak.

Stats SA sector activity and freight; Eskom Integrated Report 2025 p141; Sasol and Glencore production disclosures; Galp and Petromoc infrastructure disclosures. Detailed evidence: South Africa story v37 pp7–11.

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Substantial imports sustain the market, while customer capture determines Vopak's expansion

16.6bn L

2030 base-case imports

Activity growth broadly offsets power, rail and efficiency reductions. Domestic production stays at the 5.8bn-litre planning baseline.

2.63bn L

Illustrative Durban capture

Assumes 20% of Durban's 2025 import pool. Includes 1.32bn litres onward through Lesedi within the same fuel flow.

This is a capture scenario, not an established customer share.

Expansion follows secured incremental flow

The illustrative flow fits the preliminary working-tank calculation.

Secure additional customer volumes, establish usable capacity, and identify the constraint that investment would solve.

Invest where secured additional volumes create a demonstrated capacity shortfall.

Analytical workbook v02 base scenario; market-sizing workbook and working-capacity assessment. Capture is illustrative; Lesedi is included within Durban flow. Contracted share, product balance and usable capacity remain to be established.

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